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Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, APRIL 3, 2025 • \$4

Officials consider idea to stop TikTok ban

White House weighs deal to let Chinese firm keep ownership of algorithm

BY DREW HARWELL, CAT ZAKRZEWSKI AND NAOMI NIX

President Donald Trump on Wednesday considered a strategy to avert a TikTok ban scheduled to take effect Saturday, in a critical political test that will force the president to weigh the interests of China hawks in his own party against the online MAGA supporters who helped deliver him the White House.

The White House has reviewed a menu of options in recent weeks, including a scenario in which investors outside China would increase their ownership of TikTok while Beijing-based ByteDance would retain ownership of the powerful algorithm that recommends what people see on the popular video app, according to two people familiar with the deliberations who, like others in this article, spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss the matter publicly.

Under this scenario, ByteDance would lease the algorithm to the new entity operating TikTok in the United States, the people said.

It's unclear whether the algorithm proposal was discussed at Wednesday's meeting between Trump and top officials involved in the negotiations. White House officials declined to comment.

That plan, one of several options that have been considered, would probably face resistance from China hawks in Trump's own party, who have warned that the Chinese government could leverage the algorithm to influence the

SEE TIKTOK ON A18

Trump orders 10% tariff on all imports



DEMETRIUS FREEMAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

President Donald Trump signs two executive orders Wednesday in the Rose Garden. The administration sees the new tariffs as the start of an epic campaign to reverse more than three decades of ill-conceived economic policy and inaugurate a new "Golden Age."

PLUS EXTRA LEVIES ON SOME 60 NATIONS

Economic gamble risks a recession, experts say

BY DAVID J. LYNCH AND JEFF STEIN

President Donald Trump said Wednesday that he will impose a new 10 percent tariff on all imported goods along with higher import taxes tailored for each of about 60 countries that his advisers say maintain the largest barriers against U.S. products, in a sharp turn toward the kind of protectionism that the United States abandoned nearly a century ago.

To impose the new tariffs, the president declared a national emergency, citing the annual merchandise trade deficit that the United States has run each year since 1975.

"For decades, our country has been looted, pillaged, raped and plundered by nations near and far, both friend and foe alike," Trump said. "But it is not going to happen anymore."

The tariff increases that the president announced had little modern precedent and would erect towering impediments to products from dozens of foreign countries, many of them poor nations that embraced exporting as a tool to escape grinding poverty.

American importers, for example, SEE TARIFFS ON A12

New economic barriers

Extra tariffs were added on goods from dozens of countries, such as:

Bangladesh	37%
Cambodia	49%
China	34%
Laos	48%
Vietnam	46%

U.S. car sales: GM, Hyundai saw sharp gains in first quarter. A13

Wis. setback raises questions about Musk's future

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID, PATRICK MARLEY AND TRISHA THADANI

Liberal demonstrators for weeks have been holding up signs declaring "No one voted for Elon Musk." On Tuesday, voters in Wisconsin got the chance.

Musk's chosen candidate lost decisively in the state's Supreme Court election, delivering by far the biggest rebuke to the billionaire who has hovered over American politics since July and raising

Rebuke in state judicial election might signal bigger loss of influence

questions about his future role in the Trump administration.

The election unexpectedly developed into a clash between President Donald Trump's personality-driven politics, as represented by Musk's flashy style, and the time-

honored traditions of American democracy. At least for a moment, those traditions reasserted themselves.

The role of Musk — who is overseeing a controversial cost-cutting operation for Trump — made the race in part a referendum on him, said Barry Burden, director of the University of Wisconsin's Elections Research Center.

"He is such an unusual person and he has this outsize influence in what is going on," Burden said

of Musk, who is listed by Forbes as the world's richest person. "So that concern fit the narrative of what he was doing in the Wisconsin race, throwing his weight around and using his wealth. It was just a step too far for a lot of voters."

In Tuesday's vote — which will probably cement liberals' control of the Wisconsin Supreme Court for the next three years — Susan

SEE MUSK ON A4

@PKCapitol: Democratic wins give the party a much-needed boost. A2

Saudi Arabia emerges as key to Trump foreign policy aims

Mediation efforts likely to rekindle links between president, crown prince

BY SUSANNAH GEORGE

DUBAI — In the months since President Donald Trump was inaugurated, Saudi Arabia has found itself at the center of some of his most ambitious foreign policy and geopolitical goals, including hosting talks between U.S. and Russian officials, and facilitating negotiations both for a ceasefire and a lucrative minerals deal in Ukraine.

Trump tapped the kingdom — whose de facto leader, Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, is a close ally — to play the role of friendly but neutral mediator as he tries to reset U.S. relations with Russia and gain access to Ukraine's mineral, oil and gas reserves. On Tuesday, the president announced that he will travel to Saudi Arabia next month on the first foreign trip of his second term — a visit he said would include finalizing an agreement to have Riyadh invest upward of \$1 trillion in the U.S. economy.

"I have a very good relationship with Mohammed and the king," Trump told reporters from the Oval Office this week, referring to Mohammed's 89-year-old

father, King Salman, who has empowered his son as his successor. He described his previous visit to the kingdom as "an unbelievable day" and said he was going back now to create "tremendous amounts of jobs" in the United States.

The move by Trump to have Saudi Arabia help mediate the high-stakes negotiations stems in part from Mohammed's ties to Russian President Vladimir Putin, but it also promises to revive the relationship the president and crown prince cultivated during Trump's first term.

Both Trump and Mohammed have touted a more transactional style of diplomacy, relying less on principles or alliances and instead using multibillion-dollar trade and investment deals to cement relations with other nations. Trump shielded Mohammed from scrutiny after the CIA concluded that he ordered the assassination of journalist and Washington Post contributing columnist Jamal Khashoggi in 2018. Later, a public fund led by Mohammed invested \$2 billion in the equity firm of Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner.

When Trump talks about reaching a normalization deal between Israel and Saudi Arabia — an effort that was underway in his first term but is now on hold

SEE SAUDI ARABIA ON A10

Gaza: Israel expands operations to "seize large areas" of enclave. A10



MCKENZIE LANGE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Students listen during a welding course at Greenville Technical College in South Carolina.

Brash tactics endanger vital U.S. export

In 'home' of F-16, many fear allies will find alternatives to the jet

BY DANIELLE PAQUETTE

GREENVILLE, S.C. — Until recently, much of the world agreed: America makes the best fighter jets.

Even a half-century-old model no longer purchased by the United States military proved so popular abroad that Lockheed Martin started an assembly line here solely for foreign buyers. That export

shop turned this conservative slice of South Carolina into the "Global Home of the F-16," the governor declared, seeding hundreds of jobs while boosting Upstate part-makers. The Greenville site annually pumps \$1.3 billion into the local economy, business leaders estimate.

Now the break-everything ethos of MAGA 2.0 is rattling commerce as Washington hurls insults and tariffs at the

country's oldest customers. With President Donald Trump threatening to withdraw from historic alliances and slap steep taxes on the biggest export markets for U.S. goods, America's partners have unveiled plans to distance themselves from a White House they say is losing their trust. Outrage abroad surged last month when Trump suggested selling

SEE LOCKHEED ON A6

Judge drops corruption case against N.Y. mayor

BY SHAYNA JACOBS

NEW YORK — A judge dismissed a corruption indictment against Mayor Eric Adams on Wednesday after a controversial push by the Justice Department to terminate the case, while denying a request by federal officials for the option of reinstating the charges because it could appear that Adams was beholden to government demands.

The judge's decision, which ends the case as Adams seeks reelection, also discredited the rationale of a top Justice Department official for pursuing the dismissal. That official, Emil Bove, said the former head of the Manhattan federal prosecutor's office was politically motivated in bringing the case in September, but did not cite compelling evidence.

U.S. District Court Judge Dale Ho wrote that "the timing of this case is entirely consistent with prior public corruption prosecutions" and that the Justice Department's "appearance of impropriety" rationale is not just thin, but pretextual.

Ho's statement echoed the widely held view of legal experts and members of the public that there was an apparent deal between Adams and the federal government calling for the mayor to cooperate with President Donald

SEE ADAMS ON A2

IN THE NEWS

Putin envoy in Washington The leader of Russia's sovereign wealth fund is the most senior official to visit the United States since the invasion of Ukraine. A12

U.S. attorney for D.C. Senate Democrats demanded that nominee Ed Martin face questions at a confirmation hearing. B1

THE NATION Maine has faced investigations and arbitrary funding reversals after a White House clash. A3
The head of the program that benefits 9/11 survivors and responders was fired from HHS. A5

THE WORLD Workers at a damaged Ukrainian power plant hope a ceasefire will let them rebuild. A8
Iranian leaders traded threats with Trump as the U.S. sent warships to the region. A9

THE ECONOMY A political appointee and an informant in the Hunter Biden case is expected to lead the IRS's criminal division. A11
New rules for cryptocurrency "stablecoins" are taking shape in Congress, but the biggest one may be effectively exempted. A13

THE REGION Thousands of federal workers received new offers allowing them to resign and be paid through September. B1
A man accused of plotting to kill Supreme Court Justice Brett M. Kavanaugh intends to plead guilty, his attorneys said. B1

STYLE Kevin Young, head of the African American Museum, is on personal leave for an "undetermined period." C1

LOCAL LIVING Before investing in a sofa, you need to investigate the frame, cushions, springs and other construction elements.

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